

project.org

STUDENT HANDOUT

YELLOW LEVEL
GRADE LEVEL

The Sound of Harlem

Grades 5–8 · Music

ADMIT ONE

NAME _____ DATE _____ CLASS _____

Context: Jazz emerged from the collision of African musical traditions (call-and-response, polyrhythm, improvisation, blue notes) with American instruments and urban energy. Understanding its structure reveals why it sounded so new — and why it was so powerful.

ACTIVITY 1

Compare two recordings: blues vs big band jazz

Your teacher will play two recordings. Complete the comparison as you listen:

ELEMENT	BLUES RECORDING	BIG BAND JAZZ RECORDING
Instruments heard		
Tempo (speed)		
Mood / emotion		
Solo or ensemble?		
Call-and-response present?		
Can you hear improvisation?		

What do these two recordings share — despite sounding so different?

ACTIVITY 2

Structural analysis — 12-bar blues

The 12-bar blues uses three chords in a repeating sequence: **I** (4 bars) → **IV** (2 bars) → **I** (2 bars) → **V** (1 bar) → **IV** (1 bar) → **I** (1 bar) → **V** (1 bar)

Why does a repeating harmonic structure make improvisation easier, not harder?

Syncopation means accenting the off-beat — the "and" between beats. **Why do you think this rhythmic technique feels more energetic than playing exactly on the beat?**

ACTIVITY 3

African roots paragraph: where did jazz come from?

Jazz did not appear from nowhere. Write a paragraph (5–6 sentences) connecting the musical structures you've analyzed to their African roots. Use at least three of these terms: *call-and-response, polyrhythm, improvisation, griot tradition, blue notes, work songs.*

ACTIVITY 4

Art and music

Aaron Douglas painted *Song of the Towers* in 1934, a year after Duke Ellington recorded "Sophisticated Lady." Both are about Harlem's creative energy.

> *Aaron Douglas — Song of the Towers, 1934.* Note the concentric circles — often read as sound waves.

What specific musical element do you think the concentric circles represent? What about the figure with the saxophone?

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

The **Jazz Lab** lets you build a jazz arrangement by layering instruments. Try building the same melody in both a blues style and a big band style. What changes — and what stays the same?

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance